

A PERSONAL COOKING NOTEBOOK

Fogo Baixo

Techniques and recipes tested at home — each one as running text and as a cooking table.

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Five purées from the "Papai Papinha" series, recovered from handwritten notes between June and August 2023 — there were more than sixteen in all. All pressure-cooked, all saltless, all with texture matched to the baby's month. The lists are food families, not rules: swapping spinach for collards or ground beef for liver is the method working. Where the note gave no measurement, none was invented.

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PART ONE

Techniques

The principles that recur in nearly every recipe. Read them once; after that they are just reference.

The crisp-skin principle

Cold pan, low heat and patience produce glassy skin. Hurry produces rubber.

The fat has to render before the surface browns

Under the skin there is a layer of fat. If the surface browns before that fat melts, it stays trapped: the skin hardens on the outside and remains flabby underneath. Starting with a cold pan and raising the heat slowly gives the fat time to render and escape — the skin then fries in its own fat and turns to glass.

Water is the enemy

As long as there is moisture on the surface, the skin never gets past 100 °C, and nothing browns at 100 °C: all the heat goes into evaporating water instead of toasting. Patting dry with paper towel is not fussiness, it is the step that changes the result most. Chicken that has been marinating needs twice the care — the marinade leaves the skin soaked.

Full contact

Skin shrinks and buckles as it heats, and its middle stops touching the pan. A weight on top — another pan, a saucepan filled with water — keeps the whole surface against the metal. Without weight you get a browned rim around a pale centre.

Don't poke it

Every time you lift the piece, steam gets underneath and softens what was already crisp. Twelve to fifteen minutes without touching feels like a long time the first time. It is the right time.

Sugar burns first

Honey, soy sauce and barbecue sauce caramelize long before the skin is done. For this method, dry seasoning only: salt, herbs, pepper, paprika, garlic. Sweetness goes on later, at the table, if at all.

NOTES

- Doneness: 75 °C at the centre, or the bone pulling free easily.
- Seasoned raw chicken keeps 1-2 days in the fridge. On the second day, smell and touch it first: neutral smell and non-tacky surface means fine, but cook it that day.
- A wet marinade works against you. If you use one, drain and dry thoroughly before it hits the heat.

Salt discipline

Almost every recipe here has three or four hidden sources of sodium. Taste first, always.

Salt almost never comes only from the salt cellar

Look at the pattern. Feijoada has dried salted beef, salted ribs, ear, tail, paio and calabresa sausage — six sources before any pinch. Fried rice has bacon, calabresa, soy sauce and MSG. The orzo has a stock cube, hondashi and lemon pepper. The flap steak marinade has soy sauce, Worcestershire, fish sauce and salt. The pork medallions have soy sauce in the sauce. The escabeche has both the fish and the vinegar bath already salted. In every one of these, salting at the start is betting blind.

The practical rule

Salt goes in at the end, after tasting — and often it does not go in at all. In recipes with a reduction (the medallion sauce, the reduced steak marinade), remember that concentrating the liquid concentrates the salt with it: a sauce that tastes right halfway through the reduction will be salty by the end.

The exceptions are few and clear

Meat that will be seared takes generous salt on the surface, only as it goes to the griddle — there the salt builds crust, not interior seasoning. Boiled potatoes take salt in the water, because that is the only chance to season them inside; afterwards, a light sprinkle. Salad takes salt only as it is served, or it turns to soup. Same for vinaigrette.

When the salt has already gone too far

With salted meats, the control is the soak: 24 hours in the fridge in plenty of water, changed every 3 to 4 hours. If you had less time, taste a small raw piece before cooking — if it is still salty, pre-boil for 15 minutes instead of 10 and change the water halfway.

NOTES

- Taste the marinade liquid before reusing it as a sauce.
- If the sauce has soy sauce in it, ease off the salt everywhere else on the plate — meat and sides.
- Salting at the end can be corrected. Salting at the start cannot.

Doneness without a thermometer

Three habits solve doneness without a gadget: take it out of the fridge early, look inside, and let it rest.

The cold centre is the biggest enemy

Meat that goes from fridge straight to fire cooks outside-in with a huge gap between surface and middle — by the time the centre is right, the edge is overdone. Thin cut for the griddle: 20 to 30 minutes out of the fridge. Thick cut: 30 to 40 minutes. A whole flap steak for the oven: a full hour. This is not fussiness; it is what makes timing predictable.

Cut and peek

Without a thermometer, the method is to look. Make a small cut at the thickest point and read the colour: cold red in the middle means it needs more; warm pink is rare to medium-rare; barely pink, almost no pink and still moist is medium-well — which usually pleases most people in a piece served hot; even grey is well done, and there is no coming back. The cut loses a little juice, which matters not at all next to the cost of getting doneness wrong.

Dry browns, wet steams

The same principle as chicken skin applies to any seared meat. Paper towel on the surface before anything else — especially after marinating, which soaks it. A thin-bottomed pan plus wet meat is the combination that makes the piece release water and stew instead of browning.

Resting is not optional

Five minutes for a thin cut, eight to ten for a thick one or a whole flap steak. That is when the juices redistribute. Slicing sooner floods the board and dries out the meat — and with flap steak, slicing thin against the grain does more for tenderness than anything else in the recipe.

What does not reheat

Meat served medium does not go back on the heat: reheated medium flap steak turns to rubber. If you cannot serve immediately, change method — braised at 150–160 °C for 2.5 to 3 hours with liquid covering it reheats perfectly. Cold roast beef is the other valid path: roast to temperature, chill, slice thin and serve at room temperature. Never reheat.

NOTES

- Thermometer reference, if you have one: ~63 °C for pink pork, counting the rest; 75 °C for chicken.
- Black pepper burns on the griddle: add it after searing.
- Generous surface salt only as it goes to the heat.

Griddle, pan and the 4.5 kW burner

Too much heat is the commonest mistake for anyone with a powerful burner. Pan choice and heat recovery matter more than raw power.

Heat recovery

What matters when cold meat hits the metal is not peak temperature but how much the surface holds without collapsing. A removable griddle over the big burner, cast iron and heavy-bottomed stainless hold heat and build good fond. Thin aluminium works, but drops temperature instantly: compensate by preheating well and searing in small batches, letting the pan recover between them.

Judge by what you see

On a 4.5 kW burner, 'medium' is far less flame than it looks. Watch the orzo bubbling, the meat sizzling, the colour of the garlic — not the dial position. The pan gets very hot and holds heat: give the command and wait for it to respond, instead of going to maximum and then chasing the damage.

Garlic burns in seconds

It appears in nearly every recipe here and it is the thing that most often ruins a base. Medium-low heat, and take it off sooner than seems necessary — the hot pan keeps cooking after you turn it off. Dark garlic makes the whole dish bitter.

Preheat and test

Griddle: 5 to 8 minutes on low-medium so the heat spreads. The flame concentrates in the centre, so sear in the centre. The test is a drop of water — it should skitter and vanish in 1 to 2 seconds. Vanishing instantly means it is not yet hot enough for the Leidenfrost effect. Sitting there boiling means it has a long way to go.

Non-stick makes no sauce

It barely builds fond, and the coating degrades over high heat. If the sauce comes from the bottom of the pan — and in this book it almost always does — use stainless or iron.

NOTES

- Fond stuck to the bottom is not a mistake, it is flavour. Deglaze with water, cachaça, beer or soy sauce and scrape.
- A wide, shallow pan evaporates and absorbs evenly; a deep, narrow one piles up and smothers.
- Alcohol in a very hot pan can ignite: take it off the heat before adding cachaça or wine.

Brine fermenting without fear

Lacto-fermentation is simple and safe when three rules are followed. The fourth rule is knowing when to throw it out.

How it works

Vegetables submerged in brine ferment through lactic acid bacteria, which acidify the environment and protect against everything that spoils. Salt and acid do the preserving; time only deepens flavour, making it more sour and more rounded. That is why the timeline is flexible: a week gives a fresh result, a few months give a complex one, and neither is safer than the other.

Salt at 3% of total weight

Three per cent of the weight of vegetable plus water, not water alone. Weigh the whole thing in the jar and calculate from there. Ordinary salt works: iodine, at the levels found in table salt, does not bother the bacteria — at most it makes the brine slightly cloudy.

Everything submerged

It is above the liquid line that mould appears. A clean bag filled with 3% brine — not plain water, in case it leaks — pushed into the neck acts as a weight and seals off the air. Loose lid: fermentation releases CO₂ and a full jar overflows in the first days. Keep it on a small plate, away from sunlight. It will turn cloudy and bubble: that is correct.

Kahm or mould

A smooth white film on the surface is kahm, a harmless yeast — spoon it off and carry on. Anything fuzzy or hairy, of any colour, is mould: discard the whole batch, no scraping to save it. The smell must be sour and pleasant, like pickles; putrid means discard. A pH strip below 4 confirms it is safe.

NOTES

- Start tasting from day five to seven. The endpoint is taste, not the calendar.
- Blender only at the end. The mash version — fermented purée, salt calculated on the paste's weight, no water — is a different method: it ferments faster and dries out on top if neglected.
- Fermenting does not remove heat, it only rounds it. Calibrate the heat by tasting the raw blend: you can go up, not down.

Baby food is food families, not recipes

Good baby food is not smooth baby food. One food family at a time, rising texture, and real seasoning from the start.

Good baby food is not smooth

The goal is real cooked flavour and rising texture: a baby needs to learn to chew, and a velvety purée delays that. Hence the pressure cooker — fast, even, little water, never turning to soup — and controlled mashing at the end, from fork-mashed to finely chopped.

Seven families, and who fills each slot rotates

What holds the whole series together is not an ingredient list, it is a list of families: a starchy root for energy and body (potato, arracacha, squash, yam); a coloured vegetable for vitamins, colour and sweetness (carrot, beetroot, peas, courgette); a leafy green for iron and flavour (spinach, collards, broccoli, watercress); a protein for iron and building (beef, chicken, fish, liver, beans, chickpeas, lentils); an aromatic for the taste of real cooking (onion, garlic, leek, celery); fat; and seasoning. Each batch picks one from each, and who fills each slot rotates with the market, the season and what is in the freezer. No family is compulsory in every batch, but no batch should have only two.

THE SEVEN FAMILIES

FAMILY	WHAT IT DOES	EXAMPLES
Starchy root	energy and body	potato, arracacha, squash, yam, cassava
Coloured vegetable	vitamins, colour, sweetness	carrot, beetroot, peas, courgette, chayote
Leafy green	iron, flavour, colour	spinach, collards, broccoli, watercress, escarole
Protein	iron and building	ground beef, pork, chicken, fish, liver, beans, chickpeas, lentils
Aromatic	the taste of real cooking	onion, garlic, leek, celery
Fat	calories and fat-soluble vitamins	neutral oil (sunflower)
Seasoning	training the palate	cumin, cinnamon, bay, herbs, lime zest

The base method, in seven steps

Pulses first, if any: soaked 8 to 12 hours with the water changed, pressure-cooked alone for 20 to 25 minutes until they crush between your fingers, then set aside with a little of their liquid. Then the sofrito: neutral oil, onion and leek until soft, garlic just until fragrant. Then the protein, seared and broken up until no pink remains. The hard vegetables in roughly 2 cm cubes, with water not quite covering — do not drown them, watery baby food becomes soup — and 4 to 6 minutes of pressure counted from the hiss. The greens go in last, with the lid already off, in the residual heat. Seasoning off the heat or in the final minutes. And texture at the very end, loosened with the cooking liquid, never with cold water.

No salt, no sugar, no honey

This is the one recipe in the notebook where salt discipline is absolute: no salt at all before age one. A baby's kidneys cannot handle the sodium, and taste calibrates early — food without salt in childhood means food with less salt for life. Honey is out too, because of the risk of infant botulism before age one. What goes in instead is onion, garlic, leek, cumin, cinnamon, bay, parsley and lime zest: seasoning is not salting. It is unseasoned baby food that tastes of nothing; unsalted and well seasoned, it is good.

Baby food needs fat

A baby has a small stomach and high calorie needs, and it is fat that carries vitamins A, D, E and K out of the vegetables and into the child. Lean baby food is bulky and thin on nutrition. Here it is neutral sunflower oil, not olive oil, for two reasons: it does not compete with the flavour of the food — at this stage the baby is learning the taste of the vegetable, not of the oil — and it survives the sofrito without turning bitter. It goes in twice: in the sofrito and as a drizzle on the plate.

Liver, once a week

It is the densest source of iron available at this stage, and it was part of the rotation: beef or chicken, about 50 g per batch, well trimmed, finely chopped and cooked with the onion until no pink remains. Strong flavour — it balances well with squash, carrot or beetroot, which are sweet. Once a week is enough: liver concentrates vitamin A and should not become a daily habit.

Texture by stage

At 6 to 7 months, fork-mashed with recognisable soft pieces — do not blend. At 8 to 9 months, coarsely mashed, pieces around 5 mm, meat fibres visible. At 10 to 12 months, chopped, nearly adult food without salt. After age one it is family food, and salt comes back.

Freezing

Portion it warm into small pots or an ice-cube tray — roughly 30 ml cubes make it easy to build growing portions. Cool fast and freeze the same day, especially batches with leafy greens and beetroot, which are high in nitrate and should not sit out warming for hours. Freezer: 30 days. Fridge: 48 hours. Thaw in the fridge overnight or in a water bath, and reheat once only. Whatever is left on the baby's plate goes in the bin — saliva on the spoon contaminates the rest.

NOTES

- This chapter is a record of what I did at home, not paediatric advice. Starting solids is something to settle with the child's paediatrician — especially allergies, pace and quantities.
- Pressure does not destroy nutrients. The opposite: less time and less water than open cooking means less loss of water-soluble vitamins — and the cooking liquid goes back into the food.
- Iron: meat (or liver) + pulses + leafy greens in the same batch is the best of the series. Citrus fruit for dessert, right after the meal, helps absorption more than the zest inside the pot, which is there for aroma.
- Beetroot stains everything — purée #4 comes out purple and so does the nappy. Normal; warn whoever is on duty.
- Pulse skins: beans and chickpeas properly pressure-cooked release their skins and they vanish in the mashing. Undercooked chickpeas leave little pellets of skin — cook them longer, do not blend them harder.
- One batch a week was the rhythm; a new purée every 4 or 5 days avoids boredom and widens the repertoire.

PART TWO

Recipes

Each recipe as running text and as a cooking table. The table shows at a glance what happens in parallel.

Chicken thighs in the skillet

Glassy skin, juicy meat, finished in butter with garlic and herbs.

SERVES **2 servings**

ACTIVE **30 min**

TOTAL **55 min**

VESSEL **Heavy-bottomed skillet**

INGREDIENTS

4 bone-in, skin-on chicken thighs — ~180 g each

1 tsp salt — coarse, ground fresh

1 tsp dried herbs — thyme, rosemary or oregano

½ tsp black pepper — freshly ground

1 tbsp olive oil or neutral oil — just to coat the base

1 tbsp butter — to finish

2 cloves garlic — smashed, skin on

2 sprigs fresh rosemary or thyme — optional

METHOD

1. Take the chicken out of the fridge 20 minutes ahead. Season with salt, dried herbs and pepper.
2. Dry the skin thoroughly with paper towel. If the chicken has been marinating, this step is mandatory — the marinade leaves the skin soaked.
3. In the cold pan, add a thin film of oil, just enough to coat the base. Lay the thighs skin side down and only then turn on medium-low heat.
4. Brown for 12 to 15 minutes without moving or poking. Put a weight on top — another pan, a saucepan of water — to guarantee full contact between skin and pan.
5. Flip the pieces. Another 5 to 6 minutes on the meat side.
6. Add the butter, smashed garlic and rosemary or thyme sprigs. Tilt the pan and baste the meat with the foaming butter for 1 minute.
7. Rest 5 minutes before serving. Doneness: 75 °C at the centre, or the bone pulling free easily.

COOKING TABLE

DRY THE SKIN THOROUGHLY BEFORE YOU START									
4 bone-in, skin-on chicken thighs — ~180 g each	season and dry 20 min out of the fridge · paper towel	cold pan, skin side down only then turn on medium-low heat	brown without moving 12–15 min · with a weight on top	flip 5–6 min on the meat side	finish in butter 1 min · basting with a spoon	rest 5 min · 75 °C at the centre			
1 tsp salt — coarse, ground fresh									
1 tsp dried herbs — thyme, rosemary or oregano									
½ tsp black pepper — freshly ground									
1 tbsp olive oil or neutral oil — just to coat the base									
1 tbsp butter — to finish									
2 cloves garlic — smashed, skin on									
2 sprigs fresh rosemary or thyme — optional									

NOTES

- The fat left in the pan is an ingredient, not mess: it goes into the potatoes or the garlic rice.
- Avoid sugary seasonings (honey, soy, barbecue) — they burn before the skin is done.
- Without a weight, the skin buckles and browns only at the edges.

Chicken thighs in the air fryer

Almost as good as the skillet, for a tenth of the work. No flipping.

SERVES 2 servings ACTIVE 5 min TOTAL 30 min VESSEL Air fryer

INGREDIENTS

4 bone-in, skin-on chicken thighs

1 tsp salt

1 tsp dried herbs — or lemon pepper, or paprika

½ tsp black pepper — freshly ground

1 tsp olive oil — optional, a drizzle

METHOD

1. Season the thighs with salt, herbs and pepper. Dry the skin well with paper towel.
2. Arrange them in the basket skin up, not touching — if you crowd it, air cannot circulate and the skin steams.
3. Air fryer at 180 °C for 25 minutes. Do not flip, do not open.
4. Rest 5 minutes. Very good — just slightly less glassy than the skillet version.

COOKING TABLE

SKIN UP · DON'T CROWD THE BASKET				
4 bone-in, skin-on chicken thighs	season and dry paper towel on the skin	in the basket, skin up pieces not touching	cook at 180 °C 25 min · no flipping	rest 5 min
1 tsp salt				
1 tsp dried herbs — or lemon pepper, or paprika				
½ tsp black pepper — freshly ground				
1 tsp olive oil — optional, a drizzle				

NOTES

- If the air fryer is small, do two batches rather than stacking.
- A drizzle of oil helps browning, but is not needed: the skin's own fat is enough.

Chicken thighs in the oven

A rack over the tray is what separates crisp skin from chicken stewed in its own juices.

SERVES 4 servings ACTIVE 10 min TOTAL 50 min VESSEL Roasting tray with rack

INGREDIENTS

- 8 bone-in, skin-on chicken thighs
- 2 tsp salt
- 2 tsp dried herbs
- 1 tsp black pepper — freshly ground
- 1 tsp paprika — optional

METHOD

1. Preheat the oven to 220 °C. Season and dry the skin well.
2. Arrange the pieces on a rack set in the tray, skin up. Without the rack, the piece roasts in its own fat and the underside skin never crisps.
3. Roast 35 to 40 minutes, without turning, until the skin glazes.
4. Rest 5 minutes before serving.

COOKING TABLE

AIR HAS TO CIRCULATE UNDERNEATH				
8 bone-in, skin-on chicken thighs	season and dry paper towel on the skin	rack over the tray skin up, spaced apart	roast at 220 °C 35–40 min	rest 5 min
2 tsp salt				
2 tsp dried herbs				
1 tsp black pepper — freshly ground				
1 tsp paprika — optional				

NOTES

- The fat that drips into the tray is gold: strain it and keep it in the fridge for up to a week.
- A fan oven speeds this up: start checking at 30 minutes.

Potatoes in chicken fat

Made right after the chicken, in the rendered fat, while the meat rests.

SERVES 2 servings ACTIVE 20 min TOTAL 25 min VESSEL The chicken pan

INGREDIENTS

- 500 g potatoes — in 2 cm cubes
- 2 tbsp rendered chicken fat — whatever is left in the pan
- 2 cloves garlic — sliced
- 1 sprig rosemary — optional
- ½ tsp salt — only at the end

METHOD

1. Cut the potatoes into 2 cm cubes and dry them with paper towel — wet potato does not brown, it boils.
2. Take the chicken out and leave the rendered fat. If there is little left, top up with oil until the base is coated.
3. Put the cubes in a single layer, not stacked, over medium-high heat. If they do not fit at once, do two batches.
4. Brown for 12 to 15 minutes, stirring as little as possible — every stir interrupts the crust that is forming.
5. In the last 2 minutes, add the sliced garlic and rosemary. Salt only now: salting earlier draws out water and softens them.

COOKING TABLE

DON'T WASH THE PAN — THE FAT IS THE SEASONING				
500 g potatoes — in 2 cm cubes	cut and dry 2 cm cubes · paper towel	into the hot fat single layer, no stacking	brown 12–15 min · stir rarely	garlic, herbs and salt 2 min at the end
2 tbsp rendered chicken fat — whatever is left in the pan				
2 cloves garlic — sliced				
1 sprig rosemary — optional				
½ tsp salt — only at the end				

NOTES

- To speed things up: boil the cubes 6 min in salted water, drain, dry, then brown. The crust is even better.
- To cut the richness, a leaf salad with plain lime and salt — no oil, the fat already came from the chicken.

Garlic rice in rendered fat

One spoonful of chicken fat instead of oil changes the whole pot of rice.

SERVES 4 servings ACTIVE 10 min TOTAL 25 min VESSEL Saucepan with lid

INGREDIENTS

- 2 cups white rice — rinsed and drained
- 2 tbsp rendered chicken fat
- 4 cloves garlic — thinly sliced
- 3 cups hot water
- 1 tsp salt

METHOD

1. Heat the rendered fat and fry the sliced garlic to pale gold. Dark garlic makes the whole pot bitter — take it off sooner than seems necessary.
2. Add the rinsed, drained rice. Toast 2 minutes, until the grains turn translucent at the edges.
3. Add the hot water and salt. Boil uncovered until the water disappears from the surface and craters appear.
4. Cover, drop to the lowest heat and count 15 minutes. Do not open the pot in that time.
5. Turn it off and rest 5 minutes still covered. Fluff with a fork, never a spoon.

COOKING TABLE

HOT WATER — RICE DOES NOT LIKE THERMAL SHOCK									
2 cups white rice — rinsed and drained									
2 tbsp rendered chicken fat	fry the garlic 2 min · to pale gold	toast the rice 2 min · grains translucent	water and salt, boil uncovered, until the surface dries	cover, low heat 15 min · do not open	rest and fluff 5 min covered · fork				
4 cloves garlic — thinly sliced									
3 cups hot water									
1 tsp salt									

NOTES

- Ratio 1 part rice to 1½ water. With animal fat in the base, the grains stay looser than with oil.
- Strained chicken fat keeps a week in the fridge and three months in the freezer.

Prime rib on the griddle

Sear hard, then minimum heat flipping every minute — the griddle becomes an oven.

SERVES 1 servings ACTIVE 25 min TOTAL 45 min VESSEL Removable griddle over the big burner

INGREDIENTS

- 1 piece prime rib — ~4 cm thick
- 1 tbsp coarse salt — generous, only at the last moment
- 1 tsp lard or oil — thin film on the griddle
- ½ tsp black pepper — only after searing

METHOD

1. Dry thoroughly with paper towel and leave it 30 to 40 minutes out of the fridge. A cold centre is the biggest enemy.
2. Preheat the griddle 5 to 8 minutes on low-medium so the heat spreads. The flame concentrates in the centre, so sear there. Test with a drop of water: it should skitter and vanish in 1 to 2 seconds.
3. Generous salt only now. A thin film of lard or oil on the hot griddle.
4. Sear 2 to 3 minutes per side, until a good crust forms.
5. Drop to minimum heat and flip every minute for another 6 to 10 minutes, depending on doneness. Frequent flipping cooks the centre evenly.
6. Sear the fat edges upright, about 30 seconds, holding with tongs. Black pepper now — earlier it burns.
7. From 6 minutes into the low-heat phase, make a small cut in the centre and look: medium-rare is warm pink; cold red needs more time.
8. Rest 8 to 10 minutes. A thick cut needs that time to redistribute its juices.

COOKING TABLE

A WATER DROP SKITTERS AND VANISHES IN 1-2 SECONDS						
1 piece prime rib — ~4 cm thick	dry and temper paper towel · 30-40 min out of the fridge	salt at the last moment generous, only as it goes on	sear on the hot griddle 2-3 min per side	minimum heat, flip every minute 6-10 min · cut and peek	sear the fat edges 30 s upright, with tongs	rest 8-10 min
1 tbsp coarse salt — generous, only at the last moment						
1 tsp lard or oil — thin film on the griddle						
½ tsp black pepper — only after searing						

NOTES

- A thin cut (~2 cm) is a different method: 2 to 2.5 minutes per side flipping once only, 20–30 min out of the fridge, 5 min rest. Every extra 30 seconds changes the doneness.
- Pan sauce: return the griddle to low heat and deglaze with a little cachaça or soy sauce plus butter. If it has soy, ease off the salt elsewhere on the plate.
- Use the removable griddle, not the built-in one: the big burner has better heat recovery.

Smashed potatoes in the air fryer

Cracks and loose edges are what turn crisp. Don't tidy them up.

SERVES 2 servings ACTIVE 15 min TOTAL 40 min VESSEL Air fryer

INGREDIENTS

- 4 medium potatoes — whole, skin on
- 1 tbsp coarse salt — for the water
- 3 tbsp lard or olive oil — on both sides
- 1 pinch fine salt — light, on top
- 1 sprig rosemary

METHOD

1. Boil the potatoes whole in well-salted water until a fork slides in easily, about 20 minutes.
2. Drain and let them dry for 2 to 3 minutes, steaming off.
3. Smash each one with the base of a glass to about 1.5 cm. Cracks and ragged edges are what turn crisp — do not reshape them if they fall apart.
4. Generous fat on both sides, including the loose bits. Light salt on top (the water already seasoned the inside) and rosemary.
5. Air fryer at 200 °C for 15 to 18 minutes, no flipping, no stirring. Small basket: two batches of two potatoes — piled up they will not crisp.

COOKING TABLE

TOO LITTLE FAT IS THE #1 AIR FRYER MISTAKE					
4 medium potatoes — whole, skin on	boil whole well-salted water · ~20 min	drain and dry 2-3 min letting steam off	smash with the base of a glass to ~1.5 cm · cracks = crunch	fat, salt and rosemary both sides, including the loose bits	air fryer 200 °C 15-18 min · no flipping, no stirring
1 tbsp coarse salt — for the water					
3 tbsp lard or olive oil — on both sides					
1 pinch fine salt — light, on top					
1 sprig rosemary					

NOTES

- Overcooked potato releases more moisture: compensate with more fat.
- If they have to wait, 2 to 3 minutes back in the air fryer re-crisps them.
- An oven for four potatoes is a waste — the air fryer's circulation crisps them even better.

Pork tenderloin medallions in mustard sauce

A lean cut: sear only for the crust and let the sauce finish the cooking slowly.

SERVES 2 servings ACTIVE 30 min TOTAL 35 min VESSEL Heavy stainless or cast iron

INGREDIENTS
650 g pork tenderloin — 2 whole loins, in 2.5 cm medallions
1 tsp salt — light — the soy sauce already salts
½ tsp black pepper — freshly ground
1 tbsp oil
2 tbsp cold butter — half at the start, half at the end
1 clove garlic — smashed
2 tbsp cachaça
1 tbsp Dijon mustard
1 tbsp soy sauce
100 ml heavy cream

METHOD
1. Cut the medallions about 2.5 cm thick. What governs doneness is thickness, not diameter — if some come out wider, fine. Fold the thin tail back on itself and pin it with a toothpick to match the height.
2. Dry thoroughly with paper towel. Wet meat steams instead of browning. Season with salt and pepper only as it goes into the pan.
3. Hot pan with the oil. Lay them out without crowding — if the pan is thin-bottomed, sear in small batches and let it recover between them.
4. Sear 2 minutes, flip, 2 more minutes — only until golden crust on both sides. The centre stays raw on purpose. Remove and set aside on a plate.
5. Drop to medium heat. Add half the butter and the smashed garlic; cook just until fragrant — on this burner garlic burns in seconds.
6. Take the pan off the heat and add the cachaça (alcohol in a very hot pan can ignite). Return to the heat and scrape the base to lift the fond.
7. Add the mustard, soy sauce and cream. Stir and reduce over low heat until it thickens and coats the back of a spoon.
8. Turn off the heat and whisk in the remaining cold butter for shine.
9. Return the medallions and any juices they released; warm gently just to finish cooking. Pale pink with pink juices means done. Taste the sauce before adjusting salt.

COOKING TABLE

SEAR WITH THE CENTRE STILL RAW – THE SAUCE FINISHES IT							
650 g pork tenderloin — 2 whole loins, in 2.5 cm medallions	cut 2.5 cm and dry fold the thin tail and pin it						
1 tsp salt — light — the soy sauce already salts		season at the last moment light salt and pepper	sear and remove 2 min · flip · 2 min · raw centre				
½ tsp black pepper — freshly ground							
1 tbsp oil							
2 tbsp cold butter — half at the start, half at the end							
1 clove garlic — smashed				butter and garlic just until fragrant			
2 tbsp cachaça					off the heat: cachaça return and scrape the fond		
1 tbsp Dijon mustard						mustard, soy and cream reduce until it coats the spoon	
1 tbsp soy sauce							return the meat warm gently · taste for salt
100 ml heavy cream							

NOTES

- Avoid non-stick: it barely builds fond, and the sauce comes out flat.
- Classic variation: swap the soy for an extra pinch of salt and go heavier on the mustard. Light variation: skip the cream and make only the cachaça reduction with cold butter.
- Sides: white rice, mash or browned potatoes, and bread for the sauce.

Marinated flap steak in the oven

Served hot, medium-well, sliced thin against the grain as it goes to the table.

SERVES **4 servings** ACTIVE **20 min** TOTAL **185 min** VESSEL **Roasting tray and foil**

INGREDIENTS

1.2 kg flap steak (bavette) — whole cut
salt
soy sauce
Worcestershire sauce
fish sauce
vinegar
beer
bay leaf
black pepper
allspice

METHOD

1. Mix the marinade: salt, soy sauce, Worcestershire, fish sauce, vinegar, beer, bay, black pepper and allspice. That is four sources of sodium at once — taste the liquid before also using it as a sauce.
2. Marinate 2 hours in the fridge.
3. Take it out of the fridge 1 hour before it goes in the oven. A cold centre is the biggest enemy without a thermometer.
4. Dry the surface well with paper towel — the marinade soaks the meat.
5. Cover with foil and put it in the oven at 200 °C.
6. Start checking at 45 minutes: cut into the thickest point and read the colour. Cold red in the centre means keep going; warm pink is rare to medium-rare; barely pink, almost none, still moist is medium-well — the target. Even grey is well done and there is no going back.
7. Near the target, take off the foil and turn on the grill just to colour the surface.
8. Rest 8 to 10 minutes before slicing. Do not skip this.
9. Bring the whole hot cut to the table and slice it there, very thin and against the grain — it is the single biggest factor in this cut's tenderness.

COOKING TABLE

THE MARINADE HAS FOUR SOURCES OF SODIUM – TASTE FIRST						
1.2 kg flap steak (bavette) — whole cut						
salt	mix the marinade taste the liquid before using it	marinate 2 h refrigerated	1 h out of the fridge and dry the surface well	covered with foil, 200 °C start checking at 45 min	foil off + grill just to colour	rest and slice 8–10 min · thin, against the grain
soy sauce						
Worcestershire sauce						
fish sauce						
vinegar						
beer						
bay leaf						
black pepper						
allspice						

NOTES

- Approximate total: 50 to 65 minutes in the oven for a ~1.2 kg cut at 200 °C.
- Optional sauce: reduce the marinade liquid over low heat until concentrated. Taste for salt first — reducing intensifies it considerably.
- Reheating destroys it: medium flap steak that goes back on the heat turns to rubber. If you cannot serve immediately, braise instead (150–160 °C, 2.5–3 h with liquid covering) or serve it as cold roast beef.

Full feijoada

Correct soaking, the right order for the meats, and low heat for 4 to 5 hours. The rest is patience.

SERVES **20 servings**ACTIVE **180 min**TOTAL **300 min**VESSEL **28 cm stockpot (~10 L)**

INGREDIENTS

828 g carne seca (dried salted beef) — in 3 cm cubes

1220 g salted pork ribs — in 3 cm cubes

518 g salted pig's ear

276 g salted pig's tail

1500 g black beans — soaked 30 min

5 large onions — finely chopped

8 cloves garlic — finely chopped

$\frac{1}{3}$ cup lard — better than oil here

1 $\frac{1}{2}$ tsp ground cumin

5 leaves bay

7 l water — in proportion to the beans

1 whole orange, unpeeled

1000 g salted pork loin

366 g paio (smoked pork sausage) — whole

460 g calabresa sausage — whole

salt and black pepper — only at the end, by tasting

METHOD

1. Day 1 — Soaking. Cut the salted meats into 3 cm cubes, cover with plenty of water in separate bowls and refrigerate. Change the water every 3 or 4 hours through the day. Twenty-four hours is ideal.
2. Day 2, 5:45 — Pre-boil the salted meats in a pot of water. Ten minutes after it boils, discard the water and set the meats aside.
3. 6:30 — Fry the onion in the lard until golden, about 8 minutes. Add the garlic, cumin and bay and stir for 1 minute. If it catches slightly on the base, fine: fond is flavour, and you deglaze later.
4. 6:50 — Add the beans (soaked 30 min), 6 to 8 litres of water and the pre-boiled meats. High heat until it boils.
5. 7:40 — Once boiling, add the whole orange, drop to minimum heat and leave the lid ajar.
6. 9:20 — Pre-boil the loin separately for 10 minutes and add it to the pot, along with the whole paio and calabresa. No bacon here: all of it goes into the farofa.
7. 9:20 to 11:30 — Stir every 20 or 30 minutes, gently scraping the base. Check the water level: the meats must stay covered. Top up if needed.
8. 10:30 — Take out the orange and squeeze its juice into the pot before discarding it. Leaving it longer turns bitter.
9. 11:50 — Take out the paio and calabresa, cut into 1 cm diagonal slices and return them to the pot.
10. 12:00 — Taste for salt for the first time. It probably needs none. If the broth is thin, mash some beans against the side of the pot with the back of the ladle.
11. 12:20 — Turn it off. Rest 5 to 10 minutes with the lid ajar before serving: the broth finishes thickening.

COOKING TABLE

3 KG OF MEAT TO 1 KG OF BEANS · SALT ONLY AT THE END								
828 g carne seca (dried salted beef) — in 3 cm cubes	soak 24 h 3 cm cubes · change the water every 3–4 h	pre-boil 10 min discard the water						
1220 g salted pork ribs — in 3 cm cubes								
518 g salted pig's ear								
276 g salted pig's tail								
1500 g black beans — soaked 30 min				beans, meats and water high heat until it boils	orange and minimum heat lid ajar · ~1h40	pre-boiled loin, paio and calabresa whole · +2 h stirring every 20–30 min	remove the orange, slice the sausages squeeze the orange juice in first	taste for salt and thicken mash some beans · rest 5–10 min
5 large onions — finely chopped								
8 cloves garlic — finely chopped								
$\frac{1}{3}$ cup lard — better than oil here								
1 $\frac{1}{2}$ tsp ground cumin								
5 leaves bay								
7 l water — in proportion to the beans								
1 whole orange, unpeeled								
1000 g salted pork loin								
366 g paio (smoked pork sausage) — whole								
460 g calabresa sausage — whole								
salt and black pepper — only at the end, by tasting								

NOTES

- Feijoada has several sources of salt: the salted meats, the paio, the calabresa. Never salt before tasting at the end.
- 1.5 kg of beans makes it meat-heavy; 2 kg gives more broth to go round. Try 2 kg if the group is over 15.
- All the bacon goes into the farofa: the feijoada already has plenty of fat from paio, calabresa, ribs and loin.
- It freezes very well and improves the next day. Set aside clean containers before serving. To thaw: fridge 24 h ahead, reheat over low heat, stirring.
- Hot sauce: Tabasco is the classic, pickled biquinho peppers the mild crowd-pleaser. Sriracha and sweet chilli do not work — wrong profile.

Bacon farofa with olives

All the bacon from the feijoada ends up here — it goes further as crisp farofa.

SERVES 20 servings ACTIVE 25 min TOTAL 25 min VESSEL Large skillet

INGREDIENTS

- 240 g bacon — in 1 cm cubes
- 1 medium onion — chopped
- 2 cloves garlic — chopped
- 2 cups cassava flour — fine or coarse (biju)
- ½ cup olives — chopped
- 2 tbsp parsley — chopped
- ½ tsp black pepper — freshly ground

METHOD

1. Fry the bacon in 1 cm cubes until golden, about 7 minutes. Lift it out with a slotted spoon and set aside.
2. Pour half the fat into a small bowl, for the greens. This step matters — collards in bacon fat are unbeatable.
3. In the remaining fat, fry the chopped onion until golden, about 5 minutes. Add the garlic and cook 1 minute more.
4. Return the bacon to the pan and lower the heat.
5. Add the flour a little at a time, stirring constantly. Toast for 7 to 10 minutes until golden — fine flour needs more toasting than coarse.
6. At the end, add the chopped parsley, olives and freshly ground black pepper. Taste for salt. Keep it covered.

COOKING TABLE

FLOUR A LITTLE AT A TIME, STIRRING CONSTANTLY						
240 g bacon — in 1 cm cubes	fry the bacon ~7 min · lift out with a slotted spoon	set aside half the fat keep it for the greens				
1 medium onion — chopped			fry onion and garlic 5 min + 1 min			
2 cloves garlic — chopped				return the bacon, low heat		
2 cups cassava flour — fine or coarse (biju)					flour bit by bit, toast 7–10 min · stirring constantly	
½ cup olives — chopped						parsley, olives and pepper taste for salt
2 tbsp parsley — chopped						
½ tsp black pepper — freshly ground						

NOTES

- Scrambled egg before the flour makes a deluxe farofa.
- The bacon is the only source of fat here, and it is plenty — do not add oil.

Collard greens in bacon fat

Two to three minutes in the pan. Past that point, it's gone.

SERVES **20 servings** ACTIVE **15 min** TOTAL **15 min** VESSEL **Very hot skillet**

INGREDIENTS

- 3 bunches** collard greens — chiffonade, 2–3 mm
- 2 tbsp** bacon fat — the one you saved from the farofa
- 1 clove** garlic — chopped
- ½ tsp** salt — at the end

METHOD

1. Stack the leaves, roll them tight and slice very thin — 2 to 3 mm, with a knife. A processor bruises the leaf, cuts unevenly and oxidises it.
2. Very hot skillet with the reserved bacon fat and the chopped garlic.
3. Throw in the greens and stir fast for 2 to 3 minutes. Salt at the end. It must not overcook: it has to stay vivid green.

COOKING TABLE

IT HAS TO COME OUT VIVID GREEN			
3 bunches collard greens — chiffonade, 2–3 mm	fine chiffonade stack, roll tight, slice 2–3 mm		sauté 2–3 min · stirring fast
2 tbsp bacon fat — the one you saved from the farofa		very hot skillet fat and garlic	
1 clove garlic — chopped			
½ tsp salt — at the end			

NOTES

- It is the last thing to leave the kitchen, immediately before serving.
- No feijoada that day? Bacon fat kept in the fridge does the same job.

Bacon and calabresa fried rice

The order is the method: each step uses the fat from the one before.

SERVES **2 servings**ACTIVE **15 min**TOTAL **15 min**VESSEL **Wok or large skillet**

INGREDIENTS

80 g bacon — in small cubes

80 g calabresa sausage — very thinly sliced

2 large eggs — beaten

2 tsp ginger — grated

3 cups day-old white rice — cold and broken up

1 ½ tbsp soy sauce — down the side of the pan

1 tbsp dry sake

1 pinch MSG — optional

1 tsp sesame oil — off the heat

togarashi — to taste, to finish

spring onion — chopped, optional

METHOD

1. Mise en place first — the stir-fry is too fast to chop halfway through. Break up the rice with your hands, slice the sausage thin, beat the eggs, grate the ginger. Everything within reach before the heat goes on.
2. Almost-dry pan, medium heat. Fry the bacon until it renders and turns golden and crisp. Lift it out with a slotted spoon and leave all the fat in the pan — it is the base of everything.
3. In the bacon fat, brown the sausage until the edges colour. Remove and set aside with the bacon.
4. Pour the beaten eggs into the same fat and stir over medium heat, pulling from the bottom. Take them out still soft and creamy, before they dry — they finish cooking later.
5. Turn the heat up high. Throw in the ginger and stir just until fragrant, without burning it — on this burner that is seconds.
6. In goes the broken-up rice. Spread it in a layer and leave it still for a few seconds to catch on the pan before stirring — that is what gives the toasted bits. Then toss until the grains loosen and colour lightly.
7. Pour the soy sauce down the side of the pan, where it caramelises better than poured over the top. A splash of sake to lift the base, a pinch of MSG. Toss quickly.
8. Return the bacon, sausage and egg. Toss just until heated and the egg breaks into pieces through the rice.
9. Off the heat: a drizzle of sesame oil, togarashi and spring onion. Taste and adjust — it will rarely need salt.

COOKING TABLE

MISE EN PLACE BEFORE YOU TURN ON THE HEAT									
80 g bacon — in small cubes	fry the bacon set aside · leave all the fat								
80 g calabresa sausage — very thinly sliced		brown the calabresa until the edges colour							
2 large eggs — beaten			eggs in the same fat take them out still creamy						
2 tsp ginger — grated				ginger over high heat seconds, just until fragrant					
3 cups day-old white rice — cold and broken up					rice spread out, left alone a few seconds before stirring				
1 ½ tbsp soy sauce — down the side of the pan						soy down the side, sake, MSG toss quickly			
1 tbsp dry sake							bring it all together just until heated through		
1 pinch MSG — optional								off the heat sesame, togarashi, spring onion	
1 tsp sesame oil — off the heat									
togarashi — to taste, to finish									
spring onion — chopped, optional									

NOTES

- Cold day-old rice is mandatory: the grain has lost moisture and fries loose. Hot fresh rice releases steam and goes soggy.
- Bacon brings fat and smoky crunch; the calabresa goes in small amounts only for its paprika and garlic. Without it, compensate with more ginger and soy.
- No miso: in the heat of the pan it clumps, burns and turns to paste. Its place is soup, a marinade or a bowl sauce.
- Four sources of sodium at once — bacon, sausage, soy and MSG. Taste before you even think about salt.

Lime prawn orzo

Pre-cooked prawns only reheat at the end. The hondashi supplies the sea flavour that is missing.

SERVES **2 servings**ACTIVE **25 min**TOTAL **30 min**VESSEL **Large pan, 4–5 cm sides**

INGREDIENTS

600 ml hot water — + a kettle in reserve

1 cube vegetable stock

1 tsp hondashi (instant dashi) — up to 1½ for a stronger note

3 tbs olive oil — + a drizzle to finish

½ medium onion — very finely chopped

2 cloves garlic

160 g orzo — risoni

90 g frozen green beans — in 2 cm pieces

300 g cooked peeled prawns — thawed and well drained

1 lime — zest + juice

1 tsp lemon pepper

salt — only if needed, at the end

METHOD

1. Heat the 600 ml of water with the stock cube and hondashi until dissolved. Keep it hot on low heat beside you, with a kettle of hot water in reserve.
2. Drain the prawns thoroughly and pat them dry. They come pre-cooked — they go in only at the end. Set aside.
3. Olive oil over medium-low heat, sweat the onion until translucent. Add the garlic and cook 1 minute without colouring — on this burner garlic burns in seconds.
4. Add the dry orzo and stir 1 to 2 minutes over medium heat, until fragrant and lightly coloured. It builds flavour and helps hold the bite.
5. Add the hot stock a ladle at a time, stirring and waiting for it to absorb before the next. Medium heat, a steady cheerful bubble.
6. About 6 to 7 minutes before the end, add the beans straight from the freezer.
7. Start tasting at 7 or 8 minutes. Orzo is fast — stop at al dente, even if stock is left. Doneness rules, not the clock.
8. Minimum heat or off. Add the prawns just to warm through, 1 to 2 minutes. Never longer.
9. Off the heat: zest and half the lime juice, lemon pepper, a drizzle of oil. Stir well so it stays creamy and loose (all'onda); add another ladle of stock if needed. Taste before you even think about salt.
10. Serve immediately — orzo keeps absorbing and thickens as it sits.

COOKING TABLE

STOP AT AL DENTE, EVEN IF STOCK IS LEFT									
600 ml hot water — + a kettle in reserve	hot stock alongside dissolve the cube and hondashi			stock a ladle at a time wait for it to absorb before the next	frozen beans 6–7 min before the end	prawns, minimum heat 1–2 min just to warm through			
1 cube vegetable stock									
1 tsp hondashi (instant dashi) — up to 1½ for a stronger note									
3 tbsp olive oil — + a drizzle to finish	sweat onion and garlic medium-low · no colour		toast the orzo 1–2 min · until fragrant			off the heat zest, juice, lemon pepper, oil · taste			
½ medium onion — very finely chopped									
2 cloves garlic									
160 g orzo — risoni									
90 g frozen green beans — in 2 cm pieces									
300 g cooked peeled prawns — thawed and well drained									
1 lime — zest + juice									
1 tsp lemon pepper									
salt — only if needed, at the end									

NOTES

- 600 ml, not 700: what actually goes in is around 500 to 550 ml, the rest is slack. The mistake is dumping it all at once and drowning the pasta.
- A wide, shallow pan cooks in a thin layer and releases starch better. A deep pot piles the pasta up and it goes soggy underneath.
- Beef stock stays out of this: beef flavour fights the prawns.
- A small knob of cold butter whisked in at the end makes it silkier, if you like.

Cold farofa

The raw flours are hydrated by the oil, the lime and the water from the tomato. Nothing is cooked.

SERVES **6 servings**ACTIVE **25 min**TOTAL **55 min**VESSEL **Large bowl**

INGREDIENTS

2 hard-boiled eggs — diced small

1 **cup** white cornmeal — brings grain and crunch

1 **cup** cassava flour — absorbs the liquid and binds

4 tomatoes — seeded, in 5 mm dice

1 **cup** olives — chopped

1 carrot — grated, optional

2 **tbsp** parsley and spring onion — chopped

1 lime — juice only

1 **tsp** oregano

olive oil — in a stream, until the farofa is moist and loose

salt — by tasting, at the end

METHOD

1. Boil the eggs for 10 minutes from the boil, shock them in ice water, peel and dice.
2. Halve the tomatoes, scoop out every seed and all the jelly with a spoon, and dice into about 5 mm. This is the step that decides whether the farofa stays loose or turns soggy.
3. Chop the olives and herbs, and grate the carrot if you are using it.
4. In a large bowl, mix the two flours while still dry.
5. Add the tomato, olives, egg, carrot and herbs. Mix with your hands or a fork, without mashing.
6. Oil in a thin stream, lime juice and oregano, mixing and checking the texture as you go. The point is moist and loose: squeeze a handful and it holds, then crumbles. Dry flour still in the bottom means more oil; glossy and heavy means you went too far.
7. Salt last, by tasting. The olives already brought sodium.
8. Chill for 15 to 30 minutes to settle. Serve the same day.

COOKING TABLE

SEED THE TOMATOES — WATER IS WHAT MAKES IT SOGGY					
2 hard-boiled eggs — diced small	boil and dice the eggs 10 min • ice-water shock				
1 cup white cornmeal — brings grain and crunch			mix the dry flours 1:1 ratio		
1 cup cassava flour — absorbs the liquid and binds					
4 tomatoes — seeded, in 5 mm dice		seed the tomatoes scoop out the jelly • 5 mm dice		fold the chopped things into the flours by hand or fork, without mashing	
1 cup olives — chopped					
1 carrot — grated, optional				oil in a stream, lime and oregano until moist and loose	salt by tasting, then chill 15–30 min to settle
2 tbsp parsley and spring onion — chopped					
1 lime — juice only					
1 tsp oregano					
olive oil — in a stream, until the farofa is moist and loose					
salt — by tasting, at the end					

NOTES

- Assemble close to serving: up to about 2 hours ahead is safe. Overnight the flour finishes absorbing everything and the farofa turns pasty — this is not a make-ahead recipe.
- Two flours at 1:1 is what the handwritten note says. More cornmeal makes it grainier; more cassava, denser and wetter at the right point.
- Lime near the end keeps the herbs bright; too early and the parsley wilts and darkens.
- No heat, but genuinely raw: well-cooked egg, washed tomatoes, and keep it refrigerated until serving — especially on a hot day.
- Variations on the same base: drained sweetcorn, red pepper in small dice, or a pinch of chilli flakes.

Molho alemão

A raw barbecue sauce: pepper, tomato, onion and garlic blended with oil, vinegar and tomato paste.

SERVES ~700 ml ACTIVE 20 min TOTAL 140 min VESSEL Blender and a clean glass jar

INGREDIENTS

1 red bell pepper — or 4 — see the note

4 tomatoes

1 onion

4 cloves garlic

200 ml vinegar — 1 glass

200 ml neutral oil — 1 glass · not olive oil

1 small tin of tomato paste

salt — by tasting, at the end

METHOD

1. Pepper with no seeds and no white ribs. Tomato seeded, if you want a less watery, less bitter sauce. Onion and garlic peeled, in large pieces — the blender will handle it.
2. Blend the pepper, tomato, onion and garlic with the vinegar — the acid liquid helps the machine pull everything down. Blend to a smooth purée.
3. With the motor running, add the oil in a thin stream. Dumping it in at once will split it. The sauce lightens and thickens slightly as it takes.
4. Add the tomato paste, blending to incorporate. If you prefer to calibrate, add it by the spoonful until you reach the colour and body you want — it should run off the spoon, not stand up on it.
5. Salt, by tasting. The tomato paste already brings sodium.
6. Adjust the acidity: if it is aggressive, a pinch of sugar or a little more paste rounds it off; if it is flat, another splash of vinegar.
7. Clean glass jar, refrigerated, at least 2 hours before serving. It improves a lot by the next day, when the raw garlic loses its edge.

COOKING TABLE

OIL IN A THIN STREAM WITH THE MOTOR RUNNING – OR IT SPLITS					
1 red bell pepper — or 4 — see the note	clean and roughly chop pepper deribbed · tomato seeded	blend with the vinegar to a smooth purée	oil in a stream, motor running the sauce lightens and thickens	tomato paste colour and body · it should run off the spoon	salt and acidity, by tasting clean jar · at least 2 h in the fridge
4 tomatoes					
1 onion					
4 cloves garlic					
200 ml vinegar — 1 glass					
200 ml neutral oil — 1 glass · not olive oil					
1 small tin of tomato paste					
salt — by tasting, at the end					

NOTES

- The note says "1 red pepper or 4". With 1, the sauce is sharper and thinner; with 4, it is fuller, sweeter and much redder, with less vinegar showing — and it probably needs less paste.
- Raw garlic is the ingredient that changes most with time: on the day it is sharp and aggressive, by the next day it is round. Always worth making it the day before.
- Keeping: covered glass jar in the fridge, 2 to 3 weeks. Separation is normal — shake before serving. Always serve with a clean spoon, and never return what was left on a plate.
- Non-reactive container: glass or ceramic, never aluminium — vinegar reacts and leaves a metallic taste. Same rule as the escabeche.
- Neutral oil, not olive oil. Olive oil turns heavy and bitter in a high-speed blender; here the fat's only job is to carry the flavour of the vegetables.
- Chopped version: the same ingredients in 5 mm dice, unblended, make a pepper vinaigrette. That is a different sauce — the blender is what makes it the "alemão".

Sardine escabeche

Fried fast, then cured in a warm bath of vinegar, oil and aromatics.

SERVES **4 servings**

ACTIVE **40 min**

TOTAL **280 min**

VESSEL **Glass or ceramic dish**

INGREDIENTS

600 g fresh sardines — butterflied

1 tsp salt and pepper — on both sides

2 tbs plain flour — optional, a light dusting

120 ml olive oil

2 medium onions — in thin half-moons

4 cloves garlic — sliced

1 small carrot — thinly sliced, optional

2 leaves bay

1 tsp black peppercorns

120 ml white wine vinegar — or rice vinegar, milder

60 ml dry white wine — optional

60 ml water

1 tsp sugar — balances the acidity

parsley — chopped, to serve

METHOD

1. Dry the sardines well with paper towel and season with salt and pepper on both sides.
2. If you like, dust them lightly with flour and shake off the excess. Fry in very hot oil, in batches without crowding, 1 to 2 minutes per side, just until lightly golden. Transfer to a glass or ceramic dish.
3. In the same oil, over medium-low heat, sweat the onion, carrot, garlic, bay and peppercorns until the onion is soft and translucent — without much colour.
4. Add the vinegar, wine, water and sugar. Simmer gently for 2 to 3 minutes, just to take the raw bite off the vinegar. Taste and balance acidity and salt.
5. Pour the warm escabeche over the sardines, leaving them as covered as possible by the liquid and the onion.
6. Let it cool 20 to 30 minutes on the counter — not hours — then cover and refrigerate. Rest at least 4 hours; it comes into its own after about 12.

COOKING TABLE

NON-REACTIVE DISH · EVERYTHING SUBMERGED						
600 g fresh sardines — butterflied	dry and season paper towel · both sides	fry in batches 1–2 min per side · just to colour				
1 tsp salt and pepper — on both sides						
2 tbsp plain flour — optional, a light dusting						
120 ml olive oil						
2 medium onions — in thin half-moons						
4 cloves garlic — sliced						
1 small carrot — thinly sliced, optional						
2 leaves bay						
1 tsp black peppercorns						
120 ml white wine vinegar — or rice vinegar, milder						
60 ml dry white wine — optional						
60 ml water						
1 tsp sugar — balances the acidity						
parsley — chopped, to serve						

NOTES

- Eaten cold or at room temperature, never reheated, with bread. Keeps 4 to 5 days in the fridge and improves the next day.
- As a gift: frying late afternoon and delivering the next morning gives 14 to 16 hours of curing, the best window.
- Olive oil, not lard: lard sets solid and turns white in the fridge.
- Never aluminium or iron — vinegar reacts with metal and leaves a metallic taste.
- The fine bones soften in the acid in about a day and become edible.
- With rice vinegar, milder and sweeter, you can leave out the sugar.

Lacto-fermented hot sauce

Brazilian Tabasco style: fruity base, malagueta as the only heat. Makes 450–550 ml.

SERVES **450–550 ml**

ACTIVE **40 min**

TOTAL **10080 min**

VESSEL **Clean glass jar or bottle**

INGREDIENTS

346 g dedo-de-moça chilli (fresh cayenne-like) — fresh, trimmed

40 g malagueta (piri-piri) chilli — the volume knob — calibrate by tasting

5 cloves garlic

380 ml filtered water — enough to submerge

23 g salt — 3% of chilli + water weight

45 ml rice or cider vinegar — only at the end, to taste

METHOD

1. Remove the stems and chop coarsely by knife, into rounds. No blender at this stage — a purée is a different method, without water. Keep the seeds for medium heat. Wear a glove with the malagueta, wash your hands well and do not rub your eyes.
2. Layer into a scrupulously clean jar or bottle: dedo-de-moça, garlic and the starting amount of malagueta.
3. Taste the raw blend and adjust the heat with more malagueta if you want. You can go up, not down — and fermenting does not remove heat, it only rounds it.
4. Cover with water until submerged. Weigh the whole thing — chilli plus water — and add 3% salt. Dissolve it well.
5. Keep everything submerged: a clean bag filled with 3% brine (not plain water) pushed into the neck acts as a weight and seals off the air. No chilli above the liquid line — that is where mould starts.
6. Loose lid: fermentation releases CO₂ and a full bottle overflows in the first days. Room temperature, out of the sun, on a saucer to catch spills. It will cloud and bubble — that is right.
7. Ferment from one week to a few months. Start tasting from day five to seven; the endpoint is taste.
8. To finish: drain, reserving the brine, blend the chillies and garlic with a little of it, adjust with vinegar, bottle in clean glass and keep refrigerated.

COOKING TABLE

SALT AT 3% OF CHILLI + WATER WEIGHT · EVERYTHING SUBMERGED							
346 g dedo-de-moça chilli (fresh cayenne-like) — fresh, trimmed	chop coarsely, by knife no stems · seeds in · wear a glove	taste the raw blend adjust heat with more malagueta	cover with water in the clean jar	weigh and salt at 3% of the chilli + water weight	submerge, loose lid room temperature, out of the sun, on a saucer	ferment 1 week to a few months · taste from day 5	blend and bottle adjust with vinegar · refrigerate
40 g malagueta (piri-piri) chilli — the volume knob — calibrate by tasting							
5 cloves garlic							
380 mL filtered water — enough to submerge							
23 g salt — 3% of chilli + water weight							
45 mL rice or cider vinegar — only at the end, to taste							

NOTES

- To scale: malagueta at ~10% of the dedo-de-moça weight gives medium heat; salt always 3% of chilli + water weight.
- Kahm (a smooth white film) is a harmless yeast, spoon it off. Mould — anything fuzzy, any colour — means discarding the whole batch.
- Pimenta de cheiro is not a substitute for biquinho: it is in the habanero family and can be brutally hot. For aroma without fire, use biquinho.
- A narrow-necked bottle is the most awkward shape for keeping everything submerged.

Purée #4 — peas, beetroot and ground beef

It comes out purple and sweet — usually the favourite.

Beetroot and beef in one dish is the strongest iron pairing of the series. The beetroot takes over the colour and sweetens it considerably. It stains the nappy too: that is normal.

SERVES **8–12 frozen portions (~1.2–1.5 kg)**

ACTIVE **30 min**

TOTAL **50 min**

VESSEL **Pressure cooker**

INGREDIENTS

sunflower oil — for the sofrito, plus a drizzle to serve

1 onion

4 cloves garlic

200 g ground beef

200 g beetroot — in 2 cm cubes

200 g potato — in 2 cm cubes

water — not quite covering

230 g peas

200 g spinach

herbs and spices — no salt

METHOD

1. Peel and chop everything. Beetroot and potato in 2 cm cubes.
2. Oil in the open cooker, onion until soft, garlic just until fragrant.
3. Ground beef, breaking it up with the spoon until no pink remains.
4. Beetroot, potato and water not quite covering. Lid on, 5 to 6 minutes from the hiss.
5. Open the cooker. Peas and spinach in the residual heat, lid off.
6. Herbs and spices off the heat. Mash to the texture of the stage.
7. Portion, cool fast and freeze the same day.

COOKING TABLE

NO SALT · THE GREENS GO IN AFTER THE PRESSURE				
sunflower oil — for the sofrito, plus a drizzle to serve	sofrito onion → garlic → beef, until no pink remains	pressure 5–6 min from the hiss · beetroot is hard	lid off peas and spinach, 2 min	season and mash texture to suit the stage
1 onion				
4 cloves garlic				
200 g ground beef				
200 g beetroot — in 2 cm cubes				
200 g potato — in 2 cm cubes				
water — not quite covering				
230 g peas				
200 g spinach				
herbs and spices — no salt				

NOTES

- Frozen peas go in after opening the cooker; dried peas cook from the start with the vegetables.

Purée #5 — beans, arracacha and lime

Cinnamon with lime zest is the prettiest seasoning in the whole set of notes.

The only meatless one: the iron comes from the beans, which is absorbed less readily, so this one wants citrus fruit for dessert right after. Arracacha gives a silkier texture than potato — worth saving for when you want a softer purée.

SERVES **8–12 frozen portions (~1.2–1.5 kg)**

ACTIVE **30 min**

TOTAL **70 min**

VESSEL **Pressure cooker**

INGREDIENTS

200 g beans — soaked 8–12 h, water changed

sunflower oil

$\frac{1}{2}$ onion

4 cloves garlic

200 g arracacha (Andean root) — in 2 cm cubes

200 g carrot — in 2 cm cubes

water — not quite covering

100 g spinach

cumin

cinnamon

lime zest

METHOD

1. Soak the beans overnight, changing the water once.
2. Pressure-cook the beans alone until they crush between your fingers. Set aside with some of their liquid.
3. Oil, onion until soft, garlic just until fragrant.
4. Arracacha and carrot in cubes, the beans with some liquid, water not quite covering. Pressure.
5. Open and add the spinach in the residual heat.
6. Cumin and cinnamon in the last minutes; zest off the heat. Mash.
7. Portion, cool fast and freeze the same day.

COOKING TABLE

NO SALT · BEANS COOKED SEPARATELY, UNTIL THEY COLLAPSE					
200 g beans — soaked 8–12 h, water changed	soak and pressure, separately 8–12 h soak · 20–25 min pressure				
sunflower oil		sofrito onion until soft, garlic just until fragrant	pressure 4–5 min · with the beans and some of their liquid	lid off spinach, 2 min	season and mash zest off the heat
½ onion					
4 cloves garlic					
200 g arracacha (Andean root) — in 2 cm cubes					
200 g carrot — in 2 cm cubes					
water — not quite covering					
100 g spinach					
cumin					
cinnamon					
lime zest					

NOTES

- The zest is there for aroma, not vitamin C — what actually helps iron absorption is citrus fruit right after the meal.

Purée #6 — chickpeas, squash and beef

The most nutritionally complete: animal and plant protein in one dish.

Squash brings vitamin A and thickens by itself. Cinnamon and squash is a classic pairing and works beautifully with no sugar at all. Go easy on the water — squash and chickpeas release plenty, so start with less.

SERVES **8–12 frozen portions (~1.2–1.5 kg)**

ACTIVE **30 min**

TOTAL **75 min**

VESSEL **Pressure cooker**

INGREDIENTS

chickpeas — soaked 12 h

sunflower oil

onion

garlic

ground beef

squash — in 2 cm cubes

potato — in 2 cm cubes

water — less than usual

spinach

cinnamon

cumin

METHOD

1. Soak the chickpeas 12 h; pressure-cook them alone until they truly collapse — undercooked, the skins leave little pellets.
2. Oil, onion, garlic, then the beef until no pink remains.
3. Squash and potato in cubes, the chickpeas, water sparingly. Pressure.
4. Open and add the spinach in the residual heat.
5. Cinnamon and cumin. Mash to the texture of the stage.
6. Portion, cool fast and freeze the same day.

COOKING TABLE

NO SALT · LESS WATER THAN USUAL					
chickpeas — soaked 12 h	soak and pressure, separately 12 h soak · 25 min pressure				
sunflower oil		sofrito onion, garlic, beef until no pink remains	pressure 4 min · squash cooks fast	lid off spinach, 2 min	season and mash
onion					
garlic					
ground beef					
squash — in 2 cm cubes					
potato — in 2 cm cubes					
water — less than usual					
spinach					
cinnamon					
cumin					

NOTES

- The original note listed only ingredients, no amounts — and none were invented. The proportions of the other purées (200 g per item, 100 g of greens, 200 g of protein) fit well if you want to repeat it.

Purée #7 — pork and leek

Leek is sweeter and gentler than onion — good for a baby who balks at strong flavours.

A lean pork cut — leg or loin — shreds well under pressure and turns tender without going pasty. A fattier cut tastes better but means skimming afterwards. This was the leek's only appearance in the series and it deserved a comeback.

SERVES **8–12 frozen portions (~1.2–1.5 kg)** ACTIVE **30 min** TOTAL **50 min** VESSEL **Pressure cooker**

INGREDIENTS
sunflower oil
onion
leek — white and pale green, thinly sliced
pork — leg or loin, in small cubes
potato — in 2 cm cubes
carrot — in 2 cm cubes
water — not quite covering
spinach
spices — no salt

METHOD
1. Oil, onion and thinly sliced leek, softened without colouring.
2. Pork in small cubes, seared until no pink remains.
3. Potato and carrot in cubes, water not quite covering. Pressure.
4. Open and add the spinach in the residual heat.
5. Spices off the heat. Mash to the texture of the stage.
6. Portion, cool fast and freeze the same day.

COOKING TABLE

NO SALT · ONLY THE WHITE AND PALE GREEN OF THE LEEK				
sunflower oil	sofrito and sear onion and leek, then the pork	pressure 5 min from the hiss	lid off spinach, 2 min	season and mash
onion				
leek — white and pale green, thinly sliced				
pork — leg or loin, in small cubes				
potato — in 2 cm cubes				
carrot — in 2 cm cubes				
water — not quite covering				
spinach				
spices — no salt				

NOTES

- No measurements in the original note — nothing was invented. If you repeat it, the proportions of the others (200 g per item, 100 g of greens, 200 g of protein) are a starting point.

Purée #8 — chicken, beans and carrot

The most neutral of the series, good for a day when the baby is resisting.

Chicken with beans gives enough protein with a mild flavour. 100 g of animal protein to about 700 g of vegetables is the lightest ratio of the five — it works because the beans fill the gap.

SERVES 8–12 frozen portions (~1.2–1.5 kg) ACTIVE 30 min TOTAL 70 min VESSEL Pressure cooker

INGREDIENTS

200 g beans — soaked 8–12 h

sunflower oil

1 onion

5 cloves garlic

100 g chicken — in small cubes

200 g carrot — in 2 cm cubes

200 g potato — in 2 cm cubes

water — not quite covering

100 g spinach

cumin

cinnamon

METHOD

1. Soak the beans overnight; pressure-cook them alone until they collapse.
2. Oil, onion until soft, garlic just until fragrant — five cloves is a lot, and that's fine.
3. Chicken in small cubes until no pink remains.
4. Carrot and potato in cubes, water not quite covering. Pressure.
5. Open, add the beans and spinach in the residual heat.
6. Cumin and cinnamon. Mash to the texture of the stage.
7. Portion, cool fast and freeze the same day.

COOKING TABLE

200 g beans — soaked 8–12 h	soak and pressure, separately 20–25 min pressure				
sunflower oil					
1 onion					
5 cloves garlic					
100 g chicken — in small cubes					
200 g carrot — in 2 cm cubes					
200 g potato — in 2 cm cubes					
water — not quite covering					
100 g spinach					
cumin					
cinnamon					
		sofrito onion, garlic, chicken until no pink remains	pressure 5 min from the hiss	lid off beans and spinach, 2 min	season and mash

NOTES

- Swap the chicken for 50 g of finely chopped liver, cooked with the onion, and this becomes the highest-iron purée in the book.

Quentão with honey

Honey does not caramelize: it burns fast and turns acrid. The cost of the swap is only colour.

SERVES 6 servings ACTIVE 10 min TOTAL 30 min VESSEL Saucepan

INGREDIENTS

750 ml water
80 g fresh ginger — sliced
3 sticks cinnamon
8 cloves
1 orange peel
500 ml cachaça
120 g honey — starting point — adjust by tasting

METHOD

1. Pan with the water, ginger, cinnamon, cloves and orange peel. Bring to a boil, lower and simmer about 15 minutes, to draw out the flavour of the spices and ginger.
2. Add the cachaça and keep it on low heat, without a hard boil, to marry the flavours. Five minutes keeps the alcohol; fifteen or more makes it much gentler.
3. Turn it off — or leave it on the lowest setting — and stir in the honey until dissolved. Do not boil after this, or you lose the aroma. Taste and adjust the sweetness: honey is more assertive than sugar.
4. Strain and serve very hot, in mugs.

COOKING TABLE

DO NOT CARAMELISE THE HONEY				
750 ml water	infuse the aromatics boil, then 15 min on low	cachaça, low heat 5 min keeps the strength · 15+ softens it	turn off and dissolve the honey no boiling after this	strain and serve very hot, in mugs
80 g fresh ginger — sliced				
3 sticks cinnamon				
8 cloves				
1 orange peel				
500 ml cachaça				
120 g honey — starting point — adjust by tasting				

NOTES

- Honey is sweeter than sugar: start with 120 g and adjust at the end, never the other way round.
- Want the toasted background that caramel would give? Push the cloves and cinnamon.
- Chopped apple alongside the orange makes it fruitier.

About this notebook

This is not a cookbook in the usual sense. It is the notebook where I write down what worked in my kitchen, with the reasons why — why the pan starts cold, why salt goes in last, why fried rice needs yesterday's rice. The recipes were cooked, eaten and corrected before they became text.

Each recipe appears in four formats, because the same recipe serves different purposes. The classic view is for reading beforehand. The cooking table — an idea borrowed from *Cooking for Engineers* — shows the whole recipe at once, and is the best way to see what happens in parallel. The interactive view rescales servings and units. And kitchen mode is for dirty hands: one step at a time, with timers on the timed stages.

The quantities are the ones I use, not ones a professional test kitchen validated. Where the original recipe had no measurement, I did not invent one. Where timing depends on your stove, the text tells you what to look for instead of giving a number.

If something here helps you, good. If something is wrong, tell me.

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